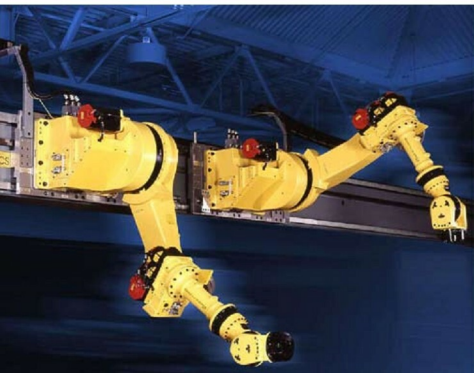


FAST-FORWARD YOUR CAREER IN AUTOMATION

Though automation has caused many a workers to lose manufacturing jobs, the field itself is creating exciting job opportunities



■ SUDESHNA DAS

Is there any industry that is likely to earn a profit during the economic downturn? The answer is automation. As corporate majors try to increase productivity, one way they are likely to achieve this is through automation.

Flexibility and efficiency are going to be the differentiators in order to quickly develop and manufacture an increasing number of products to meet the rapidly changing demands of the market. Moreover, with growing competition, "timing and speed are going to be vital for survival and success of the future organisation. No organisation in today's

age can survive without agility and responsiveness to changing environments. Systemic efficiencies can only be brought in and improved through automation. With companies becoming more and more complex and dispersed, there is need for efficient manpower," says Sumit Paul, general manager-industrial, Rockwell Automation India.

Is it an accelerator?

While employees of many global companies are bombarded by inflation and job worries, the employees in the automation industry of India by and large continue to enjoy rising salaries and strong demands for their services. Automation plays an increasingly im-

portant role in the global economy and in daily experience. Engineers strive to combine automated devices with mathematical and organisational tools to create complex systems for a rapidly expanding range of applications and human activities.

India's manufacturing sector, which is spurring the country's gross domestic product (GDP) growth, is undergoing a major transformation. It is scaling up and beginning to seek global competitiveness through the wider application of automation and IT (information technology). This trend is contributing to the robust growth of the automation industry.

"Automation is a well-established technology, both in the manufacturing sector and infrastructure. India's hope of emerging as an economic super-power depends a lot on how we groom our engineers to leverage this technology. By transferring global quality learning processes, we can convert a much larger percentage of the emerging manpower into more enriching careers," said Anup Wadhwa, director, Automation Industry Association.

According to Wadhwa, only 25 per cent of the 600,000 available engineering graduates are ready to be deployed in this industry and efforts to increase the figure need to be made. The automation industry is growing 6-8 per cent globally, whereas in countries like India and China, it is growing at more than 30 per cent.

The five-year forecast shows healthy trends and the industry will be requiring more technical graduates—both from polytechnics and engineering colleges—to join the industry. The